

Smile Portal Cost Breakdown

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Summary

The Smile portal costs about US\$190 a month in fixed costs (S\$247), and most client actions are priced above their vendor cost. The exception is a full-length phone interview to a Philippine mobile, which costs about S\$5.77 against S\$4.00 charged. Other margins range from about 25% on a 10-minute phone interview to a Malaysian mobile to over 96% on CV analysis. Live Avatar interviews earn about 71% at any length.

Fixed monthly: Vercel Pro US\$20, HeyGen LiveAvatar Essential US\$99, Vapi Core US\$29, Twilio numbers about US\$16, Hostinger VPS for n8n about US\$9 (estimate), and the Neon database about US\$17 (compute, from a one-week invoice).

Client prices: CV analysis S\$0.40, phone interview S\$4.00, Live Avatar interview S\$0.80 per started minute (2 credits a minute, one-minute minimum, S\$16.00 for the full 20 minutes).

Loses money: a 10-minute phone interview to a Philippine mobile, because Twilio charges about US\$0.29 per minute for that destination. Break-even is about 7 minutes.

Thinnest other margin: a 10-minute phone interview to a Malaysian mobile, which costs about S\$2.99 against S\$4.00 charged. A 20-minute Live Avatar interview costs about S\$4.68 against S\$16.00 charged.

No added cost: email is sent by n8n through the Gmail API, which is free, and Google Workspace is not counted as a portal cost.

What clients are charged

Clients pay S\$0.40 per Smile Credit, and each action costs a fixed number of credits regardless of how long it runs, except the Live Avatar interview, which is charged by the minute.

Action	Credits	Client price (\$S)
CV analysis	1	0.40
Phone interview, completed	10	4.00
Phone interview, incomplete	8	3.20
Phone interview, no answer	5	2.00
Live Avatar interview, per started minute (minimum 1 minute, maximum 20)	2 per minute (max 40)	0.80 per minute (max 16.00)

Credit packs: Starter 50 credits for S\$20, Standard 100 for S\$40, Bulk 2,000 for S\$800 with a 10% bonus (2,200 credits, about S\$0.36 each). A Live Avatar interview reserves 40 credits when it starts and is charged only for the minutes used. Custom purchases of 1 to 10,000 credits use the same rate. Each new organisation gets 40 free credits once.

Vendor costs

Variable costs scale with use; fixed costs are paid monthly whether or not the portal is used. Figures are US\$ from vendor pages, receipts, the Vapi dashboard and the HeyGen usage report as of 5 Oct 2026, converted at US\$1 = S\$1.30.

Variable (per use)

Item	Vendor rate	Typical cost
Voice interview, Vapi	Budgeted at \$1.50 per 10-minute interview, excluding carrier charges. Vapi's usage for ELAI (Bong) shows two recent substantial interviews at \$1.07 and \$1.78 per 10 minutes (weighted about \$1.40); an earlier report showed 18 calls, 36.6 minutes, \$4.60, or \$0.126/min. Vapi suggests allowing \$1.00–1.80 per 10 min. Both live assistants use the same stack (Soniox, GPT-4.1 Mini, Vapi Emma voice). The n8n calling workflow caps every call at 10 minutes.	\$1.50 for a 10-min call (observed \$1.07–1.78)
Voice interview, Twilio phone line	Outbound mobile rate by destination: Philippines \$0.2938/min, Singapore \$0.0578/min, Malaysia \$0.0800/min. Malaysian candidates are called from the Singapore number.	10 min: Philippines \$2.94, Singapore \$0.58, Malaysia \$0.80
Voice interview, total	Vapi plus Twilio	10 min: Philippines \$4.44, Singapore \$2.08, Malaysia \$2.30
Live Avatar FULL mode (HeyGen LiveAvatar)	2 credits per minute. The Essential plan is US\$99 for 1,100 credits a month, so 1 credit is about \$0.09 and a minute is about \$0.18. A measured 20-minute session used 39.2 credits, about \$3.53.	about \$0.18/min; \$1.80 for 10 min, \$3.60 for 20 min
CV analysis, single and bulk (n8n + OpenAI)	gpt-5-mini with low reasoning effort, \$0.25 in / \$2.00 out per 1M tokens (price list). Verified in the live n8n workflows. Failed calls retry up to 3 times.	about \$0.003–0.01 per CV
Role description parser (n8n + OpenAI)	gpt-4.1-mini, \$0.40 in / \$1.60 out per 1M tokens (from the repo definition)	under \$0.005 per role
Interview review (portal, OpenAI)	gpt-4o-mini by default, \$0.15 / \$0.60 per 1M tokens (OpenAI)	about \$0.002–0.01 per interview
Email sending (n8n Gmail node, shared Gmail account)	Gmail API standard use is free	\$0
Payments (HitPay)	Card 3%; PayNow 0.9% (min S\$0.20)	S\$0.60 on a S\$20 card top-up

Fixed (per month)

Item	Plan	Cost (US\$)
Vercel	Pro, per seat. The included \$20 usage credit applies to Vercel usage only (about \$4.29 used so far this cycle), not to Neon	20
HeyGen LiveAvatar	Essential (1,100 credits, 20-minute sessions)	99
Vapi	Core, 10 concurrent calls	29
Twilio phone numbers	Philippine number \$15.00, Singapore number from \$1.15 (list prices)	about 16

Neon Postgres	Launch, pay-as-you-go, billed through Vercel Marketplace as a separate invoice that the Pro credit does not cover. Invoice 9XQEDLWO-0003 for 25 Sep – 1 Oct: 37.177 compute-hours at \$0.106 = \$3.94 (compute only, no storage charge), about \$17 a month at that rate.	about 17
n8n hosting	Hostinger VPS (confirmed from the n8n server address); plan price not visible, KVM 2 lists about \$9	about 9
Google Workspace	Existing account used for Gmail, Drive, Sheets and Calendar; not charged to the portal	0

Baseline fixed cost is about US\$190 a month (Vercel Pro, HeyGen Essential, Vapi Core, Twilio numbers, Neon, Hostinger), or about S\$247.

Margin per action

Every action earns a positive margin except a full-length phone interview to a Philippine mobile, which costs more than the 10 credits charged. Live Avatar interviews are billed by the minute, as HeyGen bills the portal, so their margin is the same at every length.

Action	Client price (S\$)	Vendor cost (S\$)	Margin
CV analysis	0.40	0.004–0.013	over 96%
Phone interview to Philippines, 10 min	4.00	5.77	–44%
Phone interview to Philippines, 3 min	4.00	1.73	57%
Phone interview to Singapore, 10 min	4.00	2.70	32%
Phone interview to Malaysia, 10 min	4.00	2.99	25%
Live Avatar, 1 min (minimum)	0.80	0.23	71%
Live Avatar, 5 min	4.00	1.17	71%
Live Avatar, 10 min	8.00	2.34	71%
Live Avatar, 20 min (cap)	16.00	4.68	71%

Card payments cost a further 3% of each top-up. At the Bulk pack rate (S\$0.36 per credit) a 20-minute Live Avatar interview earns S\$14.55, so its margin falls to about 68%.

Illustrative month

A month with 500 CV analyses, 50 ten-minute phone interviews (assumed 20 Philippine, 20 Singapore and 10 Malaysian candidates) and 20 fifteen-minute Live Avatar interviews brings in S\$640 and leaves roughly S\$97–102 after all costs. This is an example, not a forecast; real margin depends on the country mix.

Line	S\$
Revenue (CV 200, phone 200, Live Avatar 240)	640
CV analyses (500)	2–7
Phone interviews (50, assumed mix)	199

Live Avatar (20 × 15 min)	70
Card fees (3%)	19
Fixed subscriptions, numbers, database and hosting	247
Total cost	538–543
Margin	97–102

Risks and items to verify

Phone interviews lose money to the Philippines and earn little elsewhere. A full 10-minute call to a Philippine mobile costs about S\$5.77 against S\$4.00 charged, and break-even is about 7 minutes. Options: price Philippine interviews higher, shorten the call cap, or move Philippine calls to a cheaper carrier route.

Vapi cost basis. The \$1.50 per 10 minutes is a budgeting figure from Vapi's own data for ELAI (Bong): two recent substantial interviews cost \$1.07 and \$1.78 per 10 minutes (weighted about \$1.40), and an earlier report showed 18 web calls, 36.6 minutes, 4.60 US dollars, or 0.126 per minute. It is a small sample, it excludes carrier charges because they were web calls, and Vapi does not say whether post-call analysis is included. The live Philippine assistant (e5934be9) and Singapore/Malaysia assistant (4698fa1c) use the same stack.

Neon cost is annualised from one week. The invoice covers 25 Sep – 1 Oct and is for compute only; storage was not charged that week. At 37.177 compute-hours in 7 days, the database was awake about 89% of the time at an assumed 0.25 minimum size, because n8n polls the portal every 2 to 5 minutes and never lets it suspend. The billing frequency has not been confirmed; the next invoice will show whether Neon bills weekly or monthly.

Twilio rates are list prices. They come from Twilio's pay-as-you-go pages. Your account may differ, so check the Twilio usage report for real per-call charges.

Voice calls are capped at 10 minutes. This is set in the n8n calling workflow, so a voice interview cannot cost more than the 10-minute figure.

HeyGen allowance. Essential includes 1,100 credits a month, which is 550 minutes of Live Avatar FULL mode, about 27 full-length 20-minute interviews (a measured 20-minute session used 39.2 credits). The 20-minute figure is based on one measured session, and sessions that run shorter use fewer credits. Overage past the allowance is billed per credit; the rate has not been confirmed (sources quote 0.10 to 0.12 US dollars, against about 0.09 on the plan).

Live Avatar pricing change. Live Avatar interviews moved from a flat S\$8.00 (20 credits) to S\$0.80 per started minute (2 credits). Interviews under 10 minutes now cost the client less, a 10-minute interview costs the same, and a full 20-minute interview costs S\$16.00, double the old price. Revenue from Live Avatar therefore depends on how long interviews actually run; the S\$97–102 month above assumes 15 minutes each.

Hostinger plan. n8n runs on a Hostinger VPS, but its monthly price cannot be read from n8n, so the hosting fee is an estimate.

Email limits. Sending is free, but Gmail daily sending limits apply to the connected account; these were not verified.

Currency. Vendors bill in US dollars and clients pay in Singapore dollars, so all Singapore-dollar costs assume one US dollar equals 1.30 Singapore dollars. A different rate changes the costs and margins slightly, not the client prices.

Sources: vercel.com/pricing, vapi.ai/pricing and Vapi usage report, twilio.com/voice/pricing (Philippines, Singapore, Malaysia), neon.com/pricing and Vercel invoice 9XQEDLWO-0003 (Neon compute), developers.openai.com/api/docs/pricing, intuitionlabs.ai LLM

price comparison, hitpayapp.com/pricing, developers.google.com Gmail API quota, hostinger.com/vps/n8n-hosting, HeyGen LiveAvatar plan and usage report, live n8n workflow definitions.